



The Survey Behind the Number

Student copy (project or hand out)

1 Every month the country reacts to a single set of numbers: how many jobs the economy added, and what share of workers cannot find one. On June 2 the Government Accountability Office, the agency that audits the federal government for Congress, published a report on where those numbers come from. Its finding was measured. The people who rely on the monthly jobs report told the GAO it generally meets their needs, but the data behind it faces a slow problem that has been building for about a decade.

2 The jobs report rests on two surveys, both run by the Bureau of Labor Statistics. One asks households whether their members are working or looking for work, and it is where the unemployment rate comes from; the other asks employers how many people are on their payrolls, and it is where the count of jobs added comes from. Neither is a headcount of the whole country. Each is a sample, scaled up to stand for everyone, and a sample only works if enough of the people contacted answer.

3 Fewer of them do. The share of contacted households and businesses that respond, the response rate, has fallen over roughly the last ten years, according to the GAO. That on its own does not make a number wrong. A smaller sample can still be accurate, so long as the people who drop out are a fair cross-section of the people who stay. The risk is the other case, the one statisticians call nonresponse bias: if the households and firms that quit answering differ in some consistent way from those that keep answering, the survey can lean off true without anyone seeing it lean.

4 The GAO did not say the jobs report is unreliable now. It said the agencies should be more open about the risk and more rigorous in checking for it. Its three recommendations are modest and technical: gather regular outside input on the report, document more clearly how the employer survey tests itself for that bias, and publish a plain assessment of how large the bias might be. The Bureau of Labor Statistics and the Census Bureau, for their part, plan to add an online way to answer the household survey in 2027, which they expect to lift response and lower costs. Recent funding limits, the report notes, may delay it.

5 The report's flat title undersells what rides on the numbers. The jobs figures move markets, inform the Federal Reserve's interest-rate decisions, and feed government budget plans, often within a single morning. A set of numbers that the Federal Reserve, Congress, and investors all treat as solid ground is built, in the end, on whether ordinary people and busy employers pick up and answer. The machinery has worked well for a long time. The report is a warning that one of its inputs, the public's willingness to respond, is quietly thinning.

6 For now the jobs report still does what it is built to do, and the agencies that produce it agree it can be made sturdier. The figure you read each month remains the best single measure of a vast and shifting labor market, and the survey beneath it leans on a courtesy, answering a knock or a call, that Americans extend a

little less each year. The GAO has put both on the record. The remedy it proposes is incremental, and the timeline, by the agencies' own account, is uncertain.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. Which of the following best characterizes the writer's position on the reliability of the monthly jobs report?
 - A) that it is dependable now but rests on an eroding base the responsible agencies should shore up
 - B) that it should be scrapped in favor of a full count of every household and employer
 - C) that it has already grown too inaccurate to guide interest-rate and budget decisions
 - D) that its troubles are overblown and the falling response rates pose no real risk
2. In the third paragraph, the writer distinguishes a sample that loses responses evenly from one that loses them unevenly primarily to
 - A) argue that smaller samples are always more accurate than larger ones
 - B) establish that the current jobs numbers are already distorted by missing responses
 - C) introduce the agencies' plan to let people answer the survey online
 - D) explain why a falling response rate threatens accuracy only when those who drop out differ from those who stay

Discussion questions:

1. The writer concedes that 'a smaller sample can still be accurate' before explaining when it is not. How does granting that point first change the way you weigh the concern the piece raises?
2. The piece calls the survey's foundation 'a courtesy' that Americans 'extend a little less each year.' Whose job, if anyone's, is it to keep public data accurate, and what would you be willing to do as a respondent?

Writing prompt (homework or extended in-class, Q3 argument):

The piece suggests that the trustworthiness of a public statistic can depend on something as ordinary as whether people still agree to answer a survey. Defend, challenge, or qualify the claim that citizens have a responsibility to take part in official data collection so that public numbers stay accurate. Use your own knowledge, observation, or reading.